

most people offers little or no protection that would not already be provided by regular life and disability insurance.

WHY YOU MAY NEED A WILL

Since we're on the topic of life insurance, this is as good a time as any to discuss the subject of wills. The truth is, I don't know anyone in his or her twenties who has a will. But that doesn't mean you don't need one.

If you're single, for example, you may want to leave all your possessions (even if that's just a car and a small savings account) to a friend or sibling. But according to state law, without a will, your property will be distributed to your closest relatives. If you're married, you may assume that your spouse will get everything in the event of your death. But depending on the state you live in, your parents may be entitled to a share of what you leave behind. If you're a parent, you may not want to think about what would happen to your children if you're no longer around. But without a will, a probate court will select a guardian for them. You get the picture.

The easiest way to tackle this task is to get a lawyer to draw up a will for you. If you don't have much in the way of assets and your situation is straightforward, this should cost about \$350 or less. For a list of local lawyers specializing in wills, take a look at the American Bar Association's Lawyer Locator (www.abanet.org). If you can't afford the lawyer's fee, your situation is uncomplicated, and you're willing to spend the time, you can write your own will. One book that can help is *Nolo's Simple Will Book* (Nolo Press, about \$25). You may also want to check out Nolo's Online Will, which costs about \$70 when you order it directly from the website (www.nolo.com). Keep in mind that once you start earning more money and accumulating more assets, you're going to need to update your will. But having one today is a precaution worth taking.
